Kid Apollo — Visual Direction Bible

KIDAPOLLO-VDIR-V4 FILIPPO ROMEO · CEN SPACE

This document defines the complete visual direction, interaction philosophy, technical architecture, and production strategy for the Kid Apollo interactive web experience. It is a creative direction treatment — not a feature list. Every decision inside connects back to one idea: **the porthole is the portal into Kid Apollo's world.** The experience is not a game, not an app, not a portfolio site. It is something rarer: an interactive object that feels like it belongs in the same universe as the music — a piece of the world made explorable.

The concept emerged from one observation: Kid Apollo already has a world. The rocket. The space. The feeling that someone is out there right now, floating past if you looked close enough. This project does not build a website around that world — it builds an extension of it. A place where the music and the mythology become spatial, tappable, explorable on a phone in under three seconds. The site should feel like finding a secret door backstage — somewhere private, intentional, and alive.

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Creative Direction — The Two-State Structure

The central concept is deceptively simple: a floating retro rocket drifts through space. Somewhere on its hull is a porthole. The porthole glows. The user taps it. They enter. Inside, a warm stylized room — a miniature world of objects that connect to the music, the platforms, the community. **Two states, one seamless transition, one clear invitation.** The dual-state structure does important emotional work. The exterior world is public and cosmic — the face Kid Apollo shows the world, floating through open space, iconic and unreachable. The interior is intimate and warm — the room where the music actually happens. Moving between the two states is not a navigation action. It is an emotional transition. The porthole is the threshold between the public persona and the private world. Everything in this document serves that single transition.

State 1 — Outer Space

Floating rocket — chrome, dark-red, near-black. Sheep/goat mascot with idle bob, head turn, repair beat. 3–5 decorative asteroids drifting past. Procedural starfield — sparse, slow, atmospheric. Porthole pulses with warm glow — invites entry. CTA links always visible outside the 3D scene.

State 2 — Porthole Room

Stylized warm music-room diorama. Amber / slate / cream lighting — private, musical. 5–7 clickable objects: record player, screen, phone, envelope, vinyl shelf, merch box. Hotspot labels revealed on tap. Subtle parallax depth on gentle drag. Ambient Kid Apollo track fades in on entry.

The emotional arc is precisely defined. **First second: curiosity** — the user sees a rocket floating in darkness. It is not what they expected. It is strange, specific, handmade. It does not look like any other artist site they have visited. The mascot makes a small movement. Something is alive here. **First five seconds: pleasure** — the rocket drifts. An asteroid passes. The scene is quiet but alive. There is no instruction, no loading bar, no pop-up. The experience is simply present. The user understands without being told: this is a world, not a page.

First interaction: discovery — the porthole pulses. A small label appears. The invitation is gentle, not urgent. The user taps. The camera moves forward. The rocket hull fills the screen. The porthole expands. The world inside reveals itself slowly. **Inside the room: intimacy** — the music plays softly. The room is warm. Objects glow gently. The user is no longer in public space — they are inside Kid Apollo's world. Browsing the room feels like exploring a familiar bedroom: you recognize things, you discover things, you feel the person who lives here. **After the visit: ownership** — the user leaves with a feeling of having been somewhere specific and real. Not a website. An experience. This is what creates return visits, shares, and the sense that following this artist is being part of something.

Visual DNA — Palette, Typography & Material Language

Every visual decision in this project is governed by a single non-negotiable rule: the exterior and interior must feel like the same world at different temperatures. The exterior is cool, dark, cosmic. The interior is warm, amber, intimate. But the DNA — the materials, the sticker language, the label style, the glow behavior, the typographic system — runs through both like a watermark. Remove that shared language and the porthole transition becomes a cut to a different website. Preserve it and the transition feels like walking through a door. The visual DNA is built from four elements: material language, sticker/decal system, UI label system, and glow behavior. The palette is deliberately narrow — six values cover the entire system.

Near Black — #0A0A09

Universal background and void. The canvas everything else lives against.

Chrome — #A8A4A0

Primary material. Rocket body, interior trim, fixtures, and frame details.

Warm Cream — #C8C0B2

UI layer. Labels, pill buttons, paper surfaces. The workhorse surface.

Dark Red — #7A1C1C

Accent and identity. Warning markings, exhaust cones, lamp warmth, poster borders, speaker grilles.

Amber Glow — #C87820

Everything interactive pulses with this warm amber rhythm. Porthole, asteroid labels, room hotspots. Same frequency, same easing.

Deep Slate — #1C2232

Rare cool note. Interior fill light. The visual DNA bridge between exterior and interior.

The **sticker/decal system** is the strongest identity anchor across both states. Kid Apollo graphics appear as surface marks on the rocket, repeated as actual objects inside the room — a poster, a sticker on the record player, a patch on the mascot. The **UI label system** uses warm cream on near-black, rounded pill shape, compact text. This label appears on asteroids outside and as hotspot tooltips inside — identical component, different context. The **glow behavior** ensures everything interactive pulses with the same warm amber rhythm — the porthole, the asteroid labels, the room hotspots. Same frequency, same easing. The user learns the language once and reads it everywhere.

Typography System

Two type registers — editorial for atmosphere, label for interaction — and refuses to mix them. Editorial: tall, slightly condensed, high contrast — working candidates include PP Editorial New, GT Sectra, or Söhne Breit at display weight. Label: short, uppercase, single weight, letter-spacing slightly opened (50–80 units) — working candidates include PP Neue Montreal, GT America Mono, or Söhne Mono. No more than two families in use at once. Label type never appears in italic. Editorial type never appears smaller than 24px. Mobile body type minimum is 16px, never lighter than Regular.

Material Language

Rocket materials: polished chrome (body), matte enamel apollo-red (fins, cap), brushed brass (porthole ring), warm amber glass (porthole window), scuffed black rubber (joints). The rocket reads as a chunky stylized toy — closer to a Wallace & Gromit prop than a NASA model. Room materials: warm wood (floor, shelves), woven fabric (sofa, rug), painted wall (matte, slightly cream), worn paper (posters, envelope), glass (lamp, framed art), painted enamel (TV, record player chassis), vinyl (record sleeves). The room should feel like a place where someone actually plays music — not a stylized set piece. Mascot material: character-felted — soft, slightly fuzzy, not photoreal. Closer to needle-felted craft or stop-motion puppet than plush toy.

The Rocket — Icon, Form & Identity Layer

The rocket is not a vehicle. It is an icon. It functions the way a band logo functions: instantly recognizable, specific to this artist, readable at the size of a thumbnail. Every proportional decision — the body length, the fin shape, the porthole diameter — is a branding decision as much as a 3D modeling decision. The direction is retro-futurist toy rocket, not technical spacecraft. The references that matter are 1960s tin toy rockets, 1970s science-fair posters, and handmade prop replicas. The silhouette must work as a flat shape: remove the lighting and texture, and the rocket should still read clearly on a phone screen at 200 pixels tall. The rocket on page 8 of V2 of this document was a vintage cream tin-toy direction — **that direction is retired.** The current rocket is chrome-bodied with apollo-red accents and a dark base — more graphic, more cartoonish, less "antique mall."

Form & Proportions

Compact barrel body, roughly 1.5× as tall as wide. Three or four oversized fins splaying from the base. A short, rounded nose cone — no needle-point. A dominant porthole occupying roughly 40% of the body's visible face — large enough to feel like a door, not a window. Slightly awkward stance: the rocket should look like it might tip if you breathed on it. Fins slightly oversized. Body slightly tilted (1–3°) in idle. This is what gives it character — a perfectly symmetric upright rocket reads as corporate; a slightly leaning one reads as toy. The form must work at three sizes: hero (full-screen, dominant), thumbnail (80px, mobile loading state, social share image), and signature (40px, navigation icon if ever needed). All three must be unmistakably *this rocket* and no other.

Material Zones

Body (55%): polished chrome with slight specular, showing fingerprints, light scuffs, and one or two visible dents — not damage, but use. Fins & nose cap (20%): matte enamel paint in apollo-red, with a single hairline chip at one fin tip. Porthole ring (5%): brushed brass, slightly tarnished. Porthole glass (8%): warm amber glass with internal glow — always the brightest point on the rocket. No specular highlight on the chrome may exceed the porthole's interior glow. This is non-negotiable — the porthole is the call-to-action, and it must always lead the eye. Base & joints (12%): scuffed matte black rubber and metal. Wear is concentrated in places a hand would actually touch.

Identity Layer — Stickers & Decals

Stickers, decals, and labels do the work of saying "this is Kid Apollo." KA monogram decal — primary identity mark, stylized, slightly worn, placed high on the body opposite the porthole in apollo-red on chrome. SIDE A label — vinyl-record reference, small horizontal sticker low on the body. One tour or release decal (e.g., "APOLLO TOUR 26" or "SIGNAL EP"), slightly peeling at one corner. One music-note or analog sticker — small, charming, slightly off-center. One repair mark — gaffer tape, a soldered patch, or a hand-written "DO NOT REMOVE" label. This is the Tom Sachs touch. No more than five total stickers. Nothing that says "rocket" or "spaceship" — the form already says that. No generic clip-art space iconography (planets, stars, lightning bolts). No second monogram. KA is the only repeating mark. The rocket should look like a touring object, not a moodboard.

The reference line is clear: Hergé's *Destination Moon* rocket sits at one end, Wallace & Gromit's "A Grand Day Out" rocket at the other, and Tom Sachs's plywood-and-tape NASA bricolage runs underneath both. Tintin gives us the iconic checker-pattern memorability and the chunky cigar silhouette. Wallace & Gromit gives us the slightly-awkward, slightly-handmade character that prevents the rocket from feeling too serious. Sachs reminds us that hand traces — scuffs, decals, repair marks — are what make the object feel owned. The Tintin rocket gives us the silhouette and the confidence; our rocket replaces the checker with chrome-and-apollo-red for a more graphic identity. The chunky retro-futurist energy stays.

Mascot, Outer Space Atmosphere & Decorative Asteroids

The Mascot — Baby Goat

A small baby goat lives near the rocket. It does not block the porthole, does not chase the cursor, and does not own the brand. Its job is to give the world scale, warmth, and one moment of charm. The mascot is not the protagonist. A mascot that drives navigation, has a full facial rig, and demands complex animation will consume the production budget that belongs to the porthole transition — the part of this project that actually matters most. The mascot's role is atmospheric and emotional, not functional. It makes the rocket feel occupied. The visual direction is mascot-first, not character-first. Think less Pixar protagonist, more handcrafted companion — a soft stylized creature with a readable silhouette and emotionally restrained expression. Recognizable, consistent, charming without attention-seeking.

Form: character-felted or stop-motion-puppet aesthetic. Roughly knee-height to the rocket's base. Slightly odd face — asymmetric ears, one eye slightly higher. Not cute in a corporate-mascot way; cute in a handmade-creature way. References: Aardman Animation's character animals, Wes Anderson's *Fantastic Mr. Fox* puppet style, classic Czech stop-motion (Jiří Trnka). The constraint: the pose must read at 80px tall on a mobile screen. Material: off-white wool or smooth surface against chrome and dark red. A warm visor element. A small patch echoing the rocket's sticker language.

Behavior: idle floats gently next to the rocket. Occasionally blinks. Once every 30–60 seconds, may turn its head toward the porthole when the glow pulses. Very rarely (once per minute or less), inspects a small rocket detail when the rocket "coughs" or sparks softly. None of this is a tutorial or a prompt. Animation budget: idle bob, head turn, blink, one optional beat (tool spark, antenna adjustment). Delivered as GLTF keyframe animation — no complex rig. If the build is running late, a static posed model with basic bobbing is still enough. No speaking. No tooltips. No instructional behavior. Cannot be tapped to trigger anything. If the user's pointer hovers over it, the goat may glance back — no more.

Outer Space Atmosphere

The outer space environment is not a backdrop. It is a character. But it is a supporting character, and supporting characters know when to be quiet. The biggest risk is collecting dramatic space references and accidentally building a scene where the rocket competes with its setting. The space around the rocket must be quiet enough that the rocket wins every time. The atmosphere target: cinematic emptiness. Near-black as universal background. A procedural starfield — sparse, slow, deep — that suggests infinite space without filling it. A very subtle gradient: warmer near the rocket (it has been here for a while), cooler at the edges. No planets. No nebulae. Just space, the rocket, and quiet. The reference is *not* astronomical realism. NASA-grade starfields, nebulae, galaxy backgrounds, and lens-flare suns are all wrong. The correct register is somewhere between a stage backdrop, a Joseph Cornell shadow box, and the opening shot of a Studio Ghibli film — a hand-drawn quietness, more atmospheric than informational.

Light Source & Depth Budget

A single soft key light from upper-left, off-screen. No second light, no rim light competing for the porthole's glow. The porthole is the brightest thing in the scene; the key light only models the rocket's chrome. No more than four depth layers. Anything beyond that is clutter. Layer 0 (background): deep navy gradient, top-to-bottom slightly lighter, no motion. Layer 1 (star field): sparse small dots, irregular distribution, very slow drift (1px/5s max) or none. Layer 2 (depth atmosphere): distant asteroids, tiny satellites, debris, slow parallax drift. Layer 3 (foreground): rocket + mascot + porthole, idle float, porthole glow, mascot blink. Parallax rule: Layers 1–2 move at most 30% of the cursor's input range. Layer 3 moves up to 5%. No layer ever moves fast enough to feel like vehicle motion. On mobile, parallax is driven by device tilt (gyroscope) at half the desktop magnitude.

Decorative Asteroids — Clearly Bounded: Asteroids in space are decorative atmosphere. They are **not** navigation. They have never been navigation in this version. What asteroids do: drift slowly across layer 2, add depth and scale, suggest that the world extends past the frame, reinforce that the user is *somewhere*, not floating in nothing. What asteroids do *not* do: carry links, open menus, respond to clicks, have hover states, show labels. Quantity: between 4 and 8 visible asteroids at any time. They drift in from one edge and exit the other over 60–120 seconds. New ones enter occasionally so the scene doesn't go empty. Form: matte stone, low-poly, no surface texture. They are silhouettes with slight occlusion — not detailed models. A satellite or two may appear among them at very small scale, again as silhouette. Motion budget: ≤0.3 degrees per second rotation, ≤15 pixels per second drift. This is closed.

The Porthole — Portal Logic & Transition Storyboard

If only one part of this project receives extraordinary attention, it is the porthole transition. This is the moment the concept is made visible. Everything the user felt in the exterior — the curiosity, the drifting, the slowly glowing invitation — culminates in a single, unhurried gesture that opens the world. The porthole serves three roles across the experience. Each role is visually distinct, but they share the same geometry. **Role 1: Outside CTA** — on the rocket, the porthole is the single primary action. Warm amber glow, soft pulse, a label appears nearby on hover or after 3 seconds of idle. The user is meant to tap it. Tap target: minimum 80px on mobile, with a 44px hit area extended beyond the visible glow. **Role 2: Transition mask** — during the transition, the porthole's geometry becomes the iris. The camera pushes toward the glass, the glass reflection fades, and a circular mask centered on the porthole opens outward to reveal the room. The porthole is not "going through" anywhere — it is *becoming* the room frame. **Role 3: Inside atmosphere** — in the room, the porthole appears as a small secondary window in the wall. It is not a navigation element. It may serve as a subtle "back to space" affordance, but only on hover, and even then it is a quiet option, not a primary action.

Idle Porthole

Tap Cue

Camera Push

Mask Reveal

The interaction sequence is simple and precise. The porthole pulses softly in a 3-second cycle. A small label appears: 'Enter' or 'Enter Apollo's Room'. The user taps. The camera begins to move forward — slowly, with ease-in, as if being drawn rather than pushed. The rocket hull fills the screen. The porthole rim expands. At the moment the rim passes the edge of the viewport, a circular mask begins to reveal the room interior. The exterior world does not cut away; it fades, softens, becomes the dark frame around the new world. The room arrives. Glass treatment: the porthole glass should have a faint warm reflection — not so strong it hides the interior, but enough to suggest physical depth and tactility. On tap, the reflection softens and disappears, making the glass feel like it opened. Technical implementation: GSAP for camera translation and easing. React Three Fiber camera controls for the push sequence. A CSS circular clip-path mask expanding from the porthole center outward. The transition should take 1.2–1.8 seconds total.

1. **0ms — Idle**
Porthole gently pulses. Establishes invitation. 0.33 Hz cycle, 3 seconds.

2. **0ms — Tap**
User taps porthole. User commits. Tap feedback: porthole flashes brighter, acknowledges input immediately.

3. **100–600ms — Glow**
Glow intensifies, reflection on glass fades. Builds anticipation. Audio warm-bloom note begins.

4. **600–1200ms — Push**
Camera pushes toward porthole. Rocket exits frame. Commitment to the threshold. Custom spring ease.

5. **1200–1700ms — Iris**
Porthole geometry becomes the iris. Circular mask opens outward from center. The portal becomes the frame.

6. **1700–2200ms — Arrival**
Room composition revealed. Hotspots stay dormant, then become available. Audio crests. Room is now alive.

Total duration: 1800–2200ms. Shorter than 1500ms loses the cinematic weight; longer than 2500ms feels like a loading screen. Easing on the camera push: cubic-bezier(0.65, 0, 0.35, 1) — confident in, decisive out. No bouncing, no overshoot. Easing on the mask reveal: cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1) — Material's standard, because it reads as natural. Audio cue: a single warm-bloom note begins at beat 4 and crests at beat 7. Quiet — under -18 LUFS. Subject to the audio toggle. Reduced motion path: beats 4–6 are replaced with a 400ms cross-fade from the porthole's circular shape directly to the room composition, no camera push. The user still gets a threshold moment, just a static one. Frame budget: the transition must hold 60fps on a 2020 mid-range Android phone (Snapdragon 7-series equivalent). If it cannot, the camera push gets simplified — not the mask, not the glow. The mask is the most important visual element and the glow is the most important emotional element. The camera push is the first thing to negotiate.

The Inner World — Room Diorama & Hotspot System

The interior is not a room. It is Kid Apollo's world at its most private. The music is playing. The objects have been chosen. The lighting is warm and deliberate. Entering the porthole should feel like being invited into a personal space that the artist has curated for the people who cared enough to tap. The strongest direction is the stylized music-room diorama — a miniature set that feels handmade, curated, and spatially coherent. Not a realistic spaceship interior. Think: a record label's favorite playlist made physical, compressed into one warm room. The defining reference is the cutaway shot in Wes Anderson's *The Life Aquatic with Steve Zissou*: the camera moves through a 175-foot cross-section of the Belafonte, set built at Cinecittà, designed by Mark Friedberg. Each compartment is its own small stage; the whole reads as a dollhouse with a soul. A secondary reference: Joseph Cornell's shadow boxes — small worlds, dense with personal objects, with a quality of intimate inventory. The user should feel they have looked into a private space, not a stage set.

Camera: slightly elevated, looking down at maybe 15–20°. Not a top-down dollhouse view; not eye-level either. The elevation lets the user see floor objects and shelf objects in the same composition. Cutaway treatment: the fourth wall is not invisible — it is sliced, with a visible cross-section edge (faint scanned paper, slightly torn). This sells the dollhouse logic and gives the room a frame. Density: the room is full but not chaotic. Six link objects, four to six ambient objects, two to three pieces of furniture. No object that doesn't earn its place. Lighting temperature: warm amber as primary light source. Slate-blue secondary fill from the porthole direction — the exterior light bleeding in. Soft shadows. No hard lines. The atmosphere should feel like 10pm in a musician's practice room. All static lighting is baked. One ambient practical (desk lamp). One cool blue-grey fill from the porthole direction — the exterior light bleeding in. This note is the visual DNA bridge: same temperature as exterior, transported inside.

Record Player → LISTEN

Primary link emphasis. Streaming aggregator (Linkfire / Songwhip) or direct Spotify/Apple Music. Warm spinning vinyl, soft glow under platter. Slightly warmer glow than other objects, label visible earlier than others, slight idle pulse if no interaction in 8 seconds.

CRT TV → WATCH

Secondary link. YouTube channel. Glowing screen with subtle static. Equal weight, equal label treatment with other secondary links.

Phone → FOLLOW

Secondary link. Instagram, TikTok. Soft notification glow on screen. Equal weight, equal label treatment.

Envelope / Poster → SIGN UP

Secondary link. Mailing list (Laylo / Resend). Slight lift from wall on focus. Equal weight, equal label treatment.

Vinyl Shelf → STORE

Secondary link. kidapollo.co.uk Shopify. One sleeve edge glows on focus. Equal weight, equal label treatment.

Cardboard Box → MERCH SOON

Quieter state. Holding state. Slight tape pattern, "SOON" hand-written label. Visibly present, labelled "SOON," does not invite interaction but acknowledges the future product. Pill label dimmed, no glow, no pulse.

Ambient objects (no link): a lamp with a warm shade (atmospheric light source for the room), a small upright keyboard or synth (music context, no interaction), a sofa or chair (scale anchor), one personal object — a mug, a notebook, a stack of cassettes (world-building, never clickable), the secondary porthole on the back wall (atmospheric callback to the rocket), a potted plant or two (warmth, never clickable). Every clickable object must have a **physical reason** to be clickable. A record player invites being played. A TV invites being turned on. An envelope invites being opened. The user should never have to learn "this object is a link" — the object's nature should make it obvious. This means link objects can be sized and positioned to match their function. The record player sits on a stand, at hand height. The TV sits across the room, viewable. The phone sits on a side table. The envelope is pinned to a wall. The vinyl shelf is mounted. The merch box is on the floor. None of this is decorative — it's the logic that makes the room read as a real place.

Hotspot behavior: six states. Idle (default): no mark on obvious objects; a tiny amber dot on less obvious ones. Soft pulse (after 6s idle, motion allowed): low-opacity breathing ring, 1.5s cycle. Focus (hover or near-tap): cream pill label appears anchored to object; object glow increases. Pressed (tap or click held): short cyan flash; label locks for 200ms. Expanded (optional second-line copy needed): label grows to two lines — action + hint or "Coming soon." Disabled (coming soon / merch): pill label dimmed, no glow, no pulse. Reduced motion overrides: all pulse and breathing animations are suppressed. Labels are visible from arrival, no fade-in. Focus state activates on first tap, with the link triggering on second tap (so labels are readable before commitment). Mobile rules: hit targets minimum 44×44px. Labels appear on first touch, link triggers on second touch — same two-step pattern as reduced motion. No hover-only discovery anywhere. Technical approach: CSS/HTML overlay for labels, not 3D text meshes — better typography, accessibility, and performance.

Mobile Experience, Motion Language & Audio Direction

Approximately 80–90% of Kid Apollo's audience will arrive from Instagram, on a phone, mid-scroll. **The mobile experience is the product.** Every decision in this document is tested first against a 390px viewport on a mid-range Android phone on 4G. This is the section where V2 was wrong, and it needs to be corrected in full. The 3D scene is designed for mobile first, then scales up. Composition, camera angles, hotspot sizes, animation timing, and asset budgets are all set against a 6-inch portrait phone. Desktop gets a more generous frame but no fundamentally different experience. Fallback is a true exception path, not a phone default. It loads only when WebGL is genuinely unavailable, the device fails performance gates, the user has reduced motion enabled in a strict configuration, or the user has explicitly chosen the simpler version. The mobile 3D scene must be performance-budgeted before it is design-budgeted. Every visual decision must survive a Snapdragon 7-series Android holding 60fps in the room state. If a decision can't, the decision changes — not the device target. **DECISION: The 3D scene is the mobile experience. The fallback is a resilience path, not a phone default.**

CTA Hierarchy & Fallback Strategy

PRIMARY: Listen (smartlink). SECONDARY: Watch, Follow Instagram, Follow TikTok, Sign Up (Laylo), Vinyl. DISCOVERY: porthole room hotspots (bonus, not required). The 3D adds delight. The CTA must work without it. Fallback strategy: if WebGL fails, deliver a clean static version — a still render of the rocket, the CTA stack, same visual identity. The fallback should feel like the poster version of the experience — not an error page. What the fallback contains: project name and tagline in editorial type, hero image (a static composition with the rocket and porthole, rendered once, cached), primary CTA (LISTEN), secondary CTAs (WATCH, FOLLOW, SIGN UP, VINYL), merch SOON state (disabled button), optional "ENTER ROOM" button (a low-priority option to try the 3D scene again), status copy where needed ("3D unavailable. All links still work."), audio toggle (visible but small). The fallback uses the project palette and editorial type. Buttons are cream with charcoal text. The hero image carries the warmth. Spacing is generous. It reads as a custom artist landing page — closer to a beautiful single-product Shopify page than a Linktree. The fallback is a finished product. It is not an apology.

Accessibility & Reduced Motion

Reduced motion is a first-class state, treated with the same care as the primary scene. It is not a degraded experience — it is the experience for users who need it. What changes under reduced motion: the portal transition becomes a 400ms cross-fade, no camera push, no glow ramp; hotspot pulses are suppressed; labels are visible from arrival; layer 2 parallax stops; mascot idle motion stops (mascot is present as a still image); the rocket's idle tilt is held at 0°; audio cues during the transition are suppressed. What does not change: all link actions are reachable; the room composition is the same; the label copy and hierarchy are the same. Accessibility floor: WCAG 2.1 AA contrast. All link buttons (3D and fallback) are keyboard focusable with a visible focus ring. Focus order is logical: LISTEN → WATCH → FOLLOW → SIGN UP → VINYL → MERCH → ENTER ROOM toggle. All link buttons have descriptive accessible names (aria-label where the visible text is short). Audio toggle has accessible state announcements. Color contrast: AA minimum, AAA for primary CTA.

Motion Language & Audio Direction

Motion is where premium is perceived. Not in polygon count. Not in texture resolution. In the timing of a camera push. In the easing of a label appearing. In the rhythm of an idle float. Users cannot consciously identify good motion, but they feel it immediately — this thing was made with care. The motion philosophy for this project is restraint first. Every animation must earn its frame rate cost. Idle motion exists to communicate life, not to show off. Transitions exist to orient the user, not to demonstrate technical capability. The question for every moving element is: does removing this make the experience worse, or does it simply make it quieter? If the answer is quieter, remove it. Motion makes the world feel alive without making it feel like a game. The whole motion system follows three rules: **slow ambient, fast feedback** (background and ambient motion is always slow, multi-second cycles; direct user feedback is always fast, under 200ms; anything in between — 300–800ms — is reserved for the portal transition and label appearances), **motion implies meaning** (if something moves, it should be because there's a reason — the porthole pulses because it's the action, the mascot blinks because it's alive, asteroids drift because the world has depth), and **motion has a switch** (every animation has a reduced-motion equivalent — the portal becomes a cross-fade, pulses become static states, parallax stops).

0.08Hz

Rocket Idle Bob

12s cycle. Sine, no easing.

0.33Hz

Porthole Pulse

3s cycle. Ease in-out, 40% scale.

1.8s

Portal Transition

1800–2200ms total. Custom spring ease.

100ms

Label Appear

Ease-out fast. Snaps into presence.

Easing philosophy: all motion uses custom cubic-bezier curves based on spring physics. For the porthole camera push: ease-in at 20% of the duration, linear through 60%, ease-out through the final 20%. This reads as intentional approach rather than mechanical movement. For UI labels: fast fade-in (100ms ease-out), slow fade-out (200ms ease-in). The label snaps into presence and dissolves gently. Idle rhythm: the rocket bobs at 0.08 Hz — one full cycle every 12 seconds. The mascot breathes at 0.12 Hz. The porthole pulse runs at 0.33 Hz — once every 3 seconds. These frequencies are specifically not in sync, so the scene never feels mechanical or looped. Asteroids drift at between 0.03 and 0.07 Hz depending on size, with a small random offset per asteroid.

Audio is atmospheric, not aggressive. It supports the threshold moment and adds quiet warmth to the room. It never autoplays anything that competes with the artist's actual music. Outer state: almost silent. A faint hum at -32 LUFS or quieter. Occasional very soft mechanical ticks (1–2 per minute). A barely-audible warm leak when the user hovers near the porthole — like distant music heard through a closed door. Transition: a single warm-bloom note synced to beats 4–7 of the storyboard. Peaks at -18 LUFS. A subtle glassy texture under the camera push. A small arrival cue at beat 8 — like a door closing softly behind the user. Inner state: low room ambience at -28 LUFS (slight tape hiss, the warmth of a small space, very faint vinyl crackle if the record player is the active focus). Object hover tones are tiny and clean — a small wood knock when the TV is focused, a paper rustle when the envelope is focused. Tap feedback is a soft, clean click. Audio toggle: visible in the top-right corner in both 3D and fallback. Three states: on (default), muted (user choice), and unavailable (autoplay blocked by browser, state communicated clearly). State persists across sessions. Track selection: client chooses the track. Developer handles looping and fades. MP3 at 128kbps. Stream from external URL (SoundCloud or S3) rather than bundling in the build. Hard rules: audio never autoplays at a volume that competes with anything the user might already be playing. There is never a moment where the site's audio is louder than ambient browser-level UI sounds would be. The LISTEN link is the music; everything else is texture.

Tech Stack, Asset Strategy & Performance

The technology choices follow a single principle: use the simplest tool that does the job with acceptable performance on a mid-range mobile device. The stack is deliberately conventional at the infrastructure level so all creative risk is concentrated in the 3D experience layer, where it belongs. A 3D web experience that takes more than 3 seconds to show the user something interesting on a mid-range phone has failed its primary user. Performance is not a technical concern to address after the experience is built. It is a creative constraint that shapes every asset decision, every rendering choice, and every animation budget from day one.

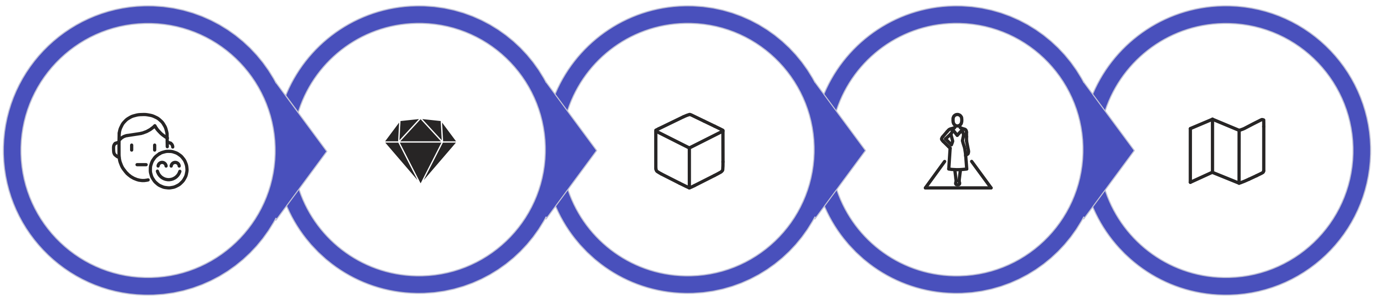
Tech Stack

Next.js 14 (App Router): server-side rendering for the page shell, fast initial load, routing structure. The 3D canvas is client-rendered; everything else can be static. This is the performance architecture that makes a 3D site feel fast. **React Three Fiber:** idiomatic Three.js inside React. Declarative scene graph makes the 3D world manageable. Drei adds helpers — OrbitControls, useGLTF, environment maps. Scene graph: canvas → lighting → rocket → mascot → asteroids → starfield → porthole. **GSAP:** all transitions, camera movements, and scroll-driven interactions. ScrollTrigger handles vertical scroll. The porthole transition is a GSAP timeline — sequential with overlap — coordinating camera movement, mask expansion, and audio fade. **Zustand (optional):** lightweight global state for the transition state machine. Tracks exterior/interior mode, transition progress, audio state. React Context is sufficient if state complexity stays low. **PostHog:** product analytics without a database. Tracks page load time, porthole tap rate, asteroid link clicks, room time, hotspot interaction heatmap, device type, WebGL availability rate. No personally identifiable data. No backend required. **Shopify Storefront API (future):** vinyl store integration. At v1 the button is a redirect to kidapollo.co.uk. Post-launch, the Shopify headless API enables embedded purchase inside the room object. Deferred to v2. **Laylo:** mailing list integration via embedded form or API. The hotspot opens a Laylo embed in a modal overlay using the same label style — it feels like part of the room, not an external popup. **Blender:** primary 3D authoring tool. Rocket, mascot, room structure modeled, UV-unwrapped, and texture-painted. DRACO compression applied to all GLB exports. Texture atlasing: maximum 2 texture slots per object. Baked lighting for static objects. **Rive (optional):** UI micro-animations requiring state machines — button hover states, asteroid label reveals, mascot repair animation if interactive triggers are needed. Lightweight web runtime, designed for browser interactive vector animation. **Vercel:** edge deployment with automatic CDN. Preview deployments per pull request. Free tier handles typical music artist traffic. GLBs and textures served with aggressive cache headers. Assets pre-compressed with DRACO and Brotli.

Asset Strategy

The asset strategy is a production decision as much as a creative one. Every asset that must be created from scratch consumes development time. Every asset that can be sourced and styled is development time given back to the transition, the mobile polish, and the motion. The discipline: custom where it matters to identity; source where it matters to time. **Must create (custom identity layer):** the rocket, the porthole frame and transition logic, the room composition and layout, the hotspot UI system, the CTA label design, the Kid Apollo sticker/decal texture. These cannot be sourced because they do not exist anywhere else. **Can source and style:** asteroid meshes (Poly Pizza, Sketchfab CC0). Room prop objects — record player, speaker, phone, screen (Sketchfab CC0 with UV-remap). Background star particles (procedural Three.js). The mascot base mesh may be sourceable — evaluate before commissioning a full custom sculpt. **AI-assisted (ideation only):** Midjourney for mood, palette, room layout exploration. ComfyUI for texture generation. These feed Blender, not the web build. **Cut if time runs out:** complex mascot repair animation, spatial audio, interior parallax, Shopify integration, gyroscope controls, extra asteroid micro-animations. Cut ruthlessly. The porthole transition is never cut.

Asset Production Pipeline



Reference

Sketch

Blockout

Model

UV Atlas

A small pipeline, run in this order, produces a shippable asset: Reference (source material — a Tintin rocket page, a Belafonte cutaway frame, a vintage room photo — stored with provenance, not raw scraping), Sketch (quick hand or digital sketch resolving silhouette and proportion), Blockout (Blender primitive blockout — tests scale and read at thumbnail), Model (final geometry — polycount target: rocket under 8k tris, room under 30k tris total), UV + atlas (single texture atlas per major object — rocket, room shell, room props — aim for 1–2 atlases per scene, not per object), Material (defined per zone — maximum 6 unique materials per scene), Bake (ambient occlusion and any baked lighting where it saves runtime cost), Decals (stickers and labels as separate small textures applied via decals, not painted into the atlas — this makes future copy edits cheap), Export (GLB with Draco compression for geometry, KTX2 for textures), In-scene QA (load in a staging build, test on the budgeted mobile target, adjust if budgets are blown). Hero assets first: rocket, porthole, room shell, six link objects, mascot. Everything else is support. Build the experience to functional first, polish second.

Performance Targets

First Contentful Paint

Under 800ms on 4G mobile. Above-the-fold HTML and CSS load instantly. CTA stack visible within 800ms.

3D Scene Visible

Under 1.5s on 4G mobile, low detail. The 3D canvas loads next, showing the rocket in a degraded low-detail state, then progressively enhancing.

Total GLB Payload

Under 2MB DRACO-compressed. Each individual model under 500KB. Texture atlas per model: maximum 2 × 1024×1024 PNG.

Draw Calls

Under 20 for exterior scene. Under 30 for interior scene. No post-processing effects on mobile — bloom and depth of field will kill frame rate on mid-range devices.

Target Frame Rate

60fps / 30fps mobile. Minimum acceptable: 24fps. If the room state drops below 40fps for more than 2 seconds, fall back to a static frame and surface the "Just the links" affordance.

Particle Count

≤800 particles (procedural). 400 in performance mode. GLTF assets are lazy-loaded: asteroid meshes load after the rocket, room assets only on porthole tap.

Load strategy: above-the-fold HTML and CSS load instantly. CTA stack visible within 800ms on 4G. The 3D canvas loads next, showing the rocket in a degraded low-detail state within 1.5s, then progressively enhancing. Graceful degradation: if WebGL is unavailable, fall back to static HTML page. If performance is poor (detected via
particle count is halved, asteroid animations pause, interior loads as static 360° image.

World Rules, Next Steps & Reference Library

Scope definition is a creative act. Knowing exactly what something is not makes it easier to make what it is with full commitment. These rules exist to protect the concept from the natural drift that happens in any production. These are the rules. Each rule rules out a category of decisions. If a new idea contradicts a rule, the default action is to simplify back to the rule, not to bend it.

→ **This project IS**

An interactive artist landing page with a 3D exterior scene, a cinematic porthole transition, and a warm stylized interior room. Mobile-first, performance-constrained, designed to serve one primary action (listening) while rewarding exploration.

→ **This project IS NOT a game**

There are no levels, no scores, no fail states. The rocket does not respond to user input with game logic. The collision system from earlier proposals is removed entirely.

→ **This project IS NOT a full e-commerce platform**

The vinyl store button is a redirect at v1. The Shopify integration is a v2 discussion. The merch section is a coming-soon placeholder.

→ **This project IS NOT a multi-page site**

One URL, one experience, one scene system. Future pages are separate sub-pages outside this production scope.

→ **This project IS NOT a CMS**

Content is hardcoded. There is no admin panel. Content changes require a developer. This is appropriate for this type and scale.

> ⚠ **Design Constitution — The Non-Negotiables:** (1) The porthole is the portal outside, not the main UI inside. The room's navigation is the room's objects. (2) Asteroids outside are decorative atmosphere. They are not links and never were. (3) Every clickable object needs a physical reason to be clickable. The affordance is the design. (4) The rocket is a chunky cartoonish chrome-and-red object, not a controllable vehicle. No steering, no boosters, no game mechanics. (5) Mobile is the primary 3D experience, not the fallback case. Fallback is a true exception path. (6) The fallback is a finished product, not an apology. Same content map, simpler interface. (7) Handmade over slick. Music-led over space-themed. Tactile over decorative. The three philosophy commitments override style preferences. (8) Motion has a switch. Every animation has a reduced-motion equivalent. No exceptions. (9) One content map drives everything. Hotspots, fallback buttons, labels, analytics — one source. (10) References must support a decision, not decorate a board. If a reference doesn't explain a choice, it doesn't belong in the bible. **Review rule:** If a new idea violates one of these rules, it needs a documented reason. The default is to simplify.

Next Steps — Sequence & Dependencies

01

Confirm Visual Direction — By Day 6

Sign-off on three emotional keywords, dual-state structure, porthole as hero interaction, and hybrid stylized-3D approach. Any concept changes are cheapest here.

02

Receive Client Sketches & References — By Day 10

Kid Apollo provides brand logo, color references, visual material from the music, and any specific objects that must appear in the room.

03

Sketch Review (Outer and Inner) — By Day 12

Outer sketch: rocket proportions, mascot position, porthole scale, asteroid placement, CTA. Inner sketch: room layout, object positions, camera angle, label positions.

04

Asset Sourcing & Base Mesh — By Day 20

Rocket base mesh evaluation. Asteroid CC0 sources. Room props sourced and UV-tested. Mascot direction confirmed: source-and-edit or custom sculpt.

05

Figma Design (Mobile-First) — By Day 28

Outer scene layout, porthole state, transition frame, interior room layout, hotspot spec, CTA stack, fallback page. Up to three client review rounds.

06

Development — By Day 55

Next.js + R3F scene + rocket + asteroid + scroll + porthole transition + interior + hotspot + audio + analytics + mobile testing + Vercel deployment.

07

Cross-Device Testing & Launch — By Day 62

QA on iOS/Android (mid-range + flagship) + desktop. Performance audit. Vercel deployment, DNS configuration, 15-day support window begins.

Band Sign-Off Points

Before modeling starts, the band's explicit sign-off is needed on the following — not "any thoughts," but specific yes/no decisions. For each of these, a "yes" advances modeling. A "change" triggers a focused redirection of just that point, not a rewrite of the whole document.

Rocket Aesthetic

Chunky cartoonish chrome body with apollo-red accents and a dominant amber porthole. Closer to a Wallace & Gromit prop than a vintage cream tin toy. Yes / change.

Mascot Species & Material

A small baby goat, character-felted / stop-motion-puppet aesthetic. Yes / change.

Navigation Model

Asteroids outside are decorative atmosphere only. The room's objects (record player, TV, phone, envelope, vinyl shelf, merch box) are the navigation. Yes / change.

Mobile-First Interpretation

The 3D experience is the primary mobile experience, not a fallback. The simpler link-stack version loads only for users who genuinely can't run the 3D or who opt for it. Yes / change.

Palette

Deep navy, warm cream, porthole amber, apollo red, soft cyan. Specific hex values in Part 4. Yes / change.

Six-Link System

LISTEN, WATCH, FOLLOW, SIGN UP, VINYL, MERCH (SOON). Specific external destinations to be confirmed per link. Yes / change.

Aesthetic Lineage

The project sits inside the Tintin / Aardman / Sachs → Wes Anderson / Cornell / Ghibli families. Yes / different reference family preferred.

Reference Library — Key Sources

Rocket references: Hergé's *Destination Moon* / *Explorers on the Moon* (1953–1954) — the chunky cigar silhouette, oversized fins, retro-futurist confidence. Aardman / Wallace & Gromit, *A Grand Day Out* (1989) — the slightly handmade quality, chunky charming proportions. Tom Sachs, *Space Program* series (2007–2022) — visible hand traces, hand-written labels, tape patches, repair marks. **Portal references:** Eero Saarinen, TWA Flight Center (1962) — brass-ringed porthole window as architectural moment, warm amber interior glow, threshold function. Submarine porthole industrial design (1940s–1960s) — rivets, brushed brass ring, thick glass with subtle distortion. Stanley Kubrick, *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968) — iris transitions, patience of the camera, circular reveals. **Room references:** Wes Anderson, *The Life Aquatic with Steve Zissou* (2004) — Belafonte cutaway, dollhouse logic, handmade quality, tight color discipline. Joseph Cornell, shadow boxes (1930s–1970s) — intimate inventory of personal objects, chosen and placed with meaning. Studio Ghibli interior spaces — warmth of small lived-in rooms, light on wooden surfaces, objects that hint at a life beyond the frame. **Mobile 3D references:** Bruno Simon's portfolio — Three.js scene that feels playful and performant on mobile, pre-baked lighting, minimal materials, compressed assets. Lusion.co and Active Theory — cinematic 3D experiences that ship to mobile, aggressive lazy loading. Apple product pages — the most-shipped, most-tested mobile 3D experience in the world, GLB-equivalent assets at small file sizes.

> **rocket → porthole → room → objects → links.** Outside: a chunky cartoonish chrome rocket floats in quiet space, the porthole glowing warm. Inside: a cutaway music room where physical objects open the artist's world. In between: a cinematic threshold that justifies itself. Underneath: a fallback that protects every user who needs it. This is what we're building.

Document V4 — drafted by Filippo Romeo / CEN Space. Valid for 30 days from delivery. All images cited for design direction only. Sketchfab CC0 assets free for commercial use; CC-BY-NC requires attribution. AI-generated images are internal ideation only. V4 image treatment: cinematic grading applied via PIL (brightness 0.58, saturation 0.38, warm tint, vignette).